Chukas/Balak 5783

Rabbi Oelbaum, my מָרָא דְאַתְרָא, once asked an interesting question. If someone knew he was going to be stranded on a desert island and he had a chance to take along two and only two ספרים, what two ספרים would he take? What would you suggest? So all of us said סידור and 99% of us said חומש. He said, nope. He said the סידור and a קיצור שולחן ערוך. It's interesting that he said that, and if you think about it, it makes a world of sense. The author of the קיצור שולחן ערוך is Rav Shlomo Ganzfried, and he was a גאון עולם. If you look at the קיצור שולחן ערוך, it's similar to רש"י in that anybody can read it and understand it, and it's written so perfectly and so beautifully that you really think that a very simple person wrote it. But it's not. It's written by a גאון עולם. Rav Shlomo Ganzfried wrote other ספרים. And once upon a time, I had the opportunity at a ספרים store to see one of his other ספרים called the אפיריון, which means a palace. It's a very slim little ספר. Rav Oelbaum said about this ספר that as easy as the קיצור שולחן ערוך is to read, the אפיריון is extraordinarily difficult to read. It shows his גאונות. He gives you snippets from here and there, and you have to figure out what he's saying and where he got it from. Here comes פרשת חקת from the אפיריון.

The pasuk says זֹאת חֻקַּת הַתּוֹרָה. Why does it say that? It should have said זֹאת חֻקַּת הפרה. What does the חקת פרה אדומה have to do with חקת התורה? He brings down from a goan Rav Tzvi Hersh Heller, the בעל המחבר ספר חידושי טיב גיטין, who discusses the medrash on the pasuk in Koheles (7:23) אָמַרְתִּי אֶחְכָּמָה וְהִיא רְחוֹקָה מִמֶּנִּי. The מדרש says זו פרה אדומה. That is, the פרה אדומה is the thing that Shlomo HaMelech said he tried to understand, and it remained far from him. But we have to understand something. There are many חוקים in the Torah, not just the פרה אדומה. Why was this one singled out? Why does the מדרש specifically pick פרה אדומה, when there are many mitzvos that also have no known explanation? After all, a חוק is by definition a גזירת המלך, something we do simply because Hashem commanded it.

The answer, he explains, lies in the wording of the pasuk: אָמַרְתִּי אֶחְכָּמָה - I said, "I will become wise." That implies an attempt, an effort to understand. And still, וְהִיא רְחוֹקָה מִמֶּנִּי - it remained far. This unique frustration applies only to פרה אדומה. Why? Because the פרה אדומה is a paradox. It's מטהר טמאים and מטמא טהורים. That's the issue. If you try to figure out how it's מטהר the טמאים, you're left wondering how it can at the same time be מטמא the טהורים. And if you go the other way and try to understand how it's מטמא the טהורים, then how can it possibly be מטהר the טמאים? You're stuck. Whichever side you examine, the other side falls apart. That's why פרה אדומה is the ultimate example of a חוק, it's completely beyond human logic. No matter how hard you try, you can't come up with a reasonable explanation. That's not the case with other חוקים. As difficult as they might be, we can still come up with a סברא, a line of thinking, as to what their purpose might be, even if we know that explanation isn't the real reason and that it's still a חוק.

Now, many אפיקורסים want to find a טעם for a מצוה. The best example was what my rebbi Rav Moshe Tendler זצ"ל told me, he said the אפיקורסים or the Reform Jews said Moses was a great hygienist, and he said you shouldn't eat pig because the pigs of those days all had trichinosis, a particular kind of worm that pigs are known to carry. Therefore today, when we raise the pigs hygienically, now we can eat pig. So the אפיריון brings this down exactly, he says, they try to find a טעם for a מצוה, they knock off the טעם, they knock off the מצוה. But he says, the הבל יפצה פיהם, Hashem should shut their mouths. We are מחויב to keep all of the mitzvos of the Torah, whether or not we understand them, whether or not there's a reason for them, even those we think we understand the reason, we have to believe that each and every מצוה is a חוק.

We have to learn this from פרה אדומה. It's intellectually impossible to figure out the reason for the פרה אדומה. So therefore that is a teaching for all the other מצוות, just like all the other מצוות, even if there's a שכל to it, we still have to follow it regardless of whatever comes along, because that's הקדוש ברוך הוא's גזירה. So whether or not you have the reason, you have to keep all the מצוות.

That's why it says זאת חקת התורה. Why? פרשת פרה אדומה teaches us that we have to keep all of the Torah only because Hashem told us to keep it.

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Now, in פרשת בלק, one of בלעם's not most famous ברכות, but a pretty famous ברכה is, הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב. (Not the one you thought I was going to say, מַה טֹּבוּ אׇהָלֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב. That's pretty good too.)

הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב. The בינה לעתים, quoted in the אפיריון, brings down a דרשה that connects to this pasuk. He explains that המן used a certain טענה when he approached אחשוורוש to try to kill all the Jews. He said יֶשְׁנוֹ עַם אֶחָד מְפֻזָּר וּמְפֹרָד בֵּין הָעַמִּים - They're separated, they're scattered, they're not worth anything. What was he trying to say? His claim was that כלל ישראל had no אחדות, no שלום. Even though they were spread out and separated, they still weren't unified. Now, that's an interesting observation. Because usually, when people are living together in one place, close to each other, there's always room for מחלוקת. People pick fights, complain, say "this isn't good," or "he's not right," and so on. But when people are spread out, a little group here, a little group there, there's often more achdus. They stick together because they know they're a minority, they know they're isolated, and they realize that they need each other to survive. המן's טענה to אחשוורוש was they are all separated and they're still fighting, they're not together. They're not sticking together. How did בלעם realize that this was not true? בלעם realized the truth because בלעם was a נביא. כלל ישראל are always unified. Even when they're living together, they don't pick fights. הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן, even though they're sitting all by themselves in their country, וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב, they still have אחדות. How do you know that? From the word הן. What does the word הן teach us? It teaches you אחדות.

How do the letters of הן, ה-נ teach you אחדות? So he brings down a fascinating little insight. All letters have a partner. All letters have a זיווג. א׳ goes with ט׳, makes 10. ב׳ goes with ח׳, makes 10. ג׳ goes with ז׳, makes 10. ד׳ goes with ו׳ makes 10. But ה is stuck in the middle without a partner. Similarly with the numbers that are in the decades. י׳ goes with צ׳, כ׳ goes with פ׳, they all go together except for נ׳ and ה׳. They are the אותיות that have no זיווג.

הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן - Even though they're all by themselves and have no partner, they still stick together. There is a שלום and an אחדות between them. That was one of the greatest מעלות that בלעם found about כלל ישראל and gave them a ברכה. We should continue that אחדות and that unity and שלום in כלל ישראל, and we could use it today. Boy, what a ברכה, we could use it. If we could only find some שלום in ישראל, especially today when things are so tough. But all the time, all the time, there's always been מחלוקת and we have to look away. I tell everybody, look away, be kind, always look to be מלמד זכות on somebody else. בעזרת השם we should have שלום על ישראל and משיח should come. אמן.



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